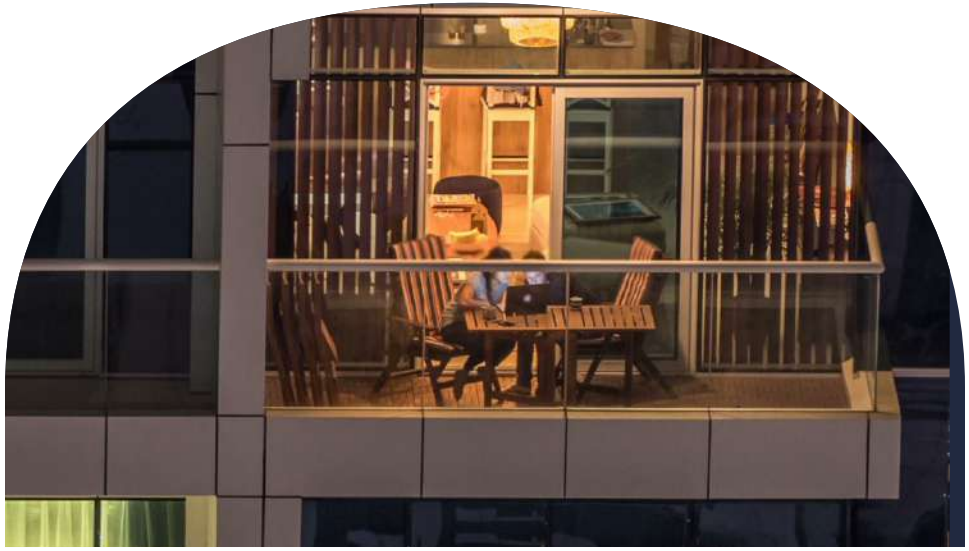


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7 Key Steps to ADA Compliance on Property Websites

ADA GUIDELINES
for Property Managers

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Why it Matters

Any organization that could be categorized as “public accommodation” falls under the jurisdiction of the **Americans with Disabilities Act** (ADA), which aims to prohibit discrimination and guarantee equal opportunities for all.

Your property isn’t the only thing that must be accessible to individuals with disabilities. Website design can help or hinder accessibility to information for users with blindness, low vision, color blindness, or hearing difficulties.



eCommerce, retail, housing and other types of organizations have an obligation to incorporate inclusive design to ensure that their websites accommodates users with disabilities.

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Stay Informed



Inclusive design tactics not only make your site more accessible to your elderly and disabled users, but also your entire user base as well.

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Levels of Accessibility for ADA Compliance

Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1, the latest ADA guideline iteration, has expanded existing guidelines to include more provisions for those with disabilities.

- **Level A:** The minimum legal standard (WCAG 2.0).
- **Level AA:** A more comprehensive compliance, seen as the most appropriate standard for websites. **Multi-family organizations should comply at least at this level.**
- **Level AAA:** The strictest compliance standard (WCAG 2.1), which includes 17 new success criteria related to mobile accessibility.

Hundreds of lawsuits have been filed against cities and counties for websites that do not comply with the ADA.

If you need assistance to make your digital properties compliant with WCAG 2.0 or 2.1, contact a reputable accessibility consulting company to help you meet your organization's obligations.

7 KEY AREAS FOR ADA COMPLIANCE

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Many of ADA's guidelines are technical and intended for developers to implement. Work with accessibility experts to evaluate your website or oversee development of a new site to ensure inclusive design. Your team should also learn the basics of the following guidelines if they will be updating the website or adding content.

1 IMAGES

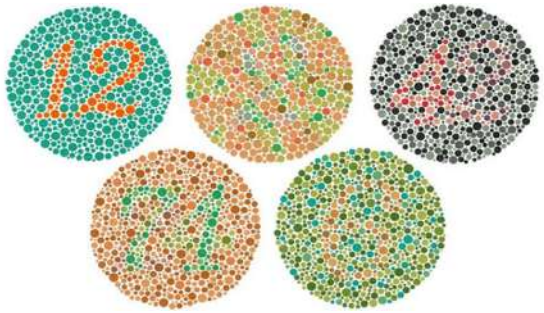
Individuals with impaired vision rely on assistive screen reading software or Braille displays to help them navigate web pages. These technologies cannot read your images.

- ALT tags (brief descriptions of a picture) help the user understand your content while also helping with your search engine optimization (SEO) rankings. (To learn more about this important and often overlooked website element, explore The 5 Golden Rules of Compliant Alt Text.)

- Blinking, flashing or flickering graphics can cause seizures in those who are susceptible to them. Avoid them or make sure users can pause or stop the distracting feature.

- Don't put large amounts of text on images. Assistive screen readers can't read the text on JPGs and PNGs, nor will search engines be able to crawl the text embedded in an image.

- Consider contrast and visibility when selecting text and background colors. About 1 in 20 people are color-blind, which means they and others with low vision won't be able to make out your content. Tag your site's colors in the HTML so assistive technology will know what to adjust. A good rule of thumb is for the background color and text color to have a 50% contrast difference.





2 PDF FORMS

The majority of recent ADA website lawsuits are focused on user inability to access and fill out website forms. It is more difficult for disabled users (and all other users) to download, read, complete and return a PDF than for their screen reader to read content directly on the website.

For example, Pet Policies, Privacy Policies and any type of disclaimers should not be in a PDF because they limit access to that important information. Instead, you should include this information on a page on your site. This allows screen readers to easily scan and dictate to the user.

Online forms and services and content on your website save you time and money in the long run, as well.

3 LINKS

Instead of composing hyperlinks that say “Click here,” alert your readers to where they’ll be directed or what they will be clicking to.

4 AUDIO & VIDEO TRANSCRIPTS

Provide closed-captioning to your audio clips, video announcements and walkthroughs, so that those with hearing and visual disabilities won’t be left behind.

Closed captioning is also useful to a growing number of non-hearing-impaired users who watch videos with the sound off.





5 KEYBOARD NAVIGATION

Ensure that every interactive element is accessible when someone is navigating with their keyboard or using other assistive technologies that imitate keyboard functionality. Don't forget to include visual and hover states, too,

6 PROPER FORM MARKUP

This will guarantee that assistive technologies can complete your site's forms. Include a proper label for every form field, as well as text that denotes which fields are required.

7 MOBILE FRIENDLINESS

The majority of users today are coming to your site from some sort of mobile device. Making sure your site is mobile friendly should be a requirement for every website. If your site is not optimized for mobile, you are doing a disservice to over half of your visitors, not just those with disabilities.

READY TO GET STARTED?

These are just a few of the basic guidelines your website should follow to provide the best overall user experience for everyone.

We recommend consulting with a provider who is well versed in ADA website compliance, accessibility and inclusive design.

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QUICK ADA COMPLIANCE CHECKLIST

Ensure that your website meets these standards:

- [ ] Provides text alternatives for all non-text content.
- [ ] Provides synchronized alternatives for multimedia.
- [ ] Ensures that information and structure can be separated from presentation.
- [ ] Makes it easy to distinguish foreground information from its background. (Contrast should be 50% difference)
- [ ] Makes all functionality operable via a keyboard interface.
- [ ] Allows users to control time limits on their reading or interaction.
- [ ] Allows users to avoid content that could cause seizures due to photosensitivity.
- [ ] Provides mechanisms to help users find content, orient themselves within it, and navigate through it.
- [ ] Helps users avoid mistakes and makes it easy to correct mistakes that do occur.
- [ ] Makes text content readable and understandable.
- [ ] Makes the placement and functionality of content predictable.
- [ ] Supports compatibility with current and future user agents. (including assistive technologies)
- [ ] Ensures that content is accessible or provides an accessible alternative.

Stay Up to Date with New ADA Compliances

ADA compliance is still new and continues to change. Because inclusive design should be a priority for every property management organization, keeping current with ADA updates should be a priority.

Learn more with these resources:

SIGN UP FOR EMAIL UPDATES FROM ADA.GOV

SEE TOPICS OF INTEREST

EXPLORE WCAG 2.0

EXPLORE WCAG 2.1

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